

vate one-on-one session. Feel free to experiment a bit and find what suits the character the best, and don't worry if it shifts a bit as the prelude goes on — such changes are a natural part of these sessions. Think of it like the pilot episode of a television show, where character portrayals are often different from what's depicted during the actual season.

The prelude is also a good time to work directly with the Storyteller to establish setting and backstory elements that you want to see come into play later. Just like the Storyteller may use foreshadowing to set up plot points that come up later, a player can use the prelude to suggest potential subplots and twists he wants to see in the future. Sometimes this sort of element can come up spontaneously in response to what's going on in the prelude, as characters or events inspire a new direction.

For instance, the Storyteller might decide to start the prelude as a character is at home with his husband, just to start off with a scene of normal domesticity. However, the player suddenly decides that he wants the relationship to be troubled, with the possibility of it coming under real pressure later in the chronicle. Hearing this, the Storyteller takes a moment to think, then launches into a scene where the two of them are arguing about money after what should have been a nice relaxing dinner date. The player dives in, and the prelude goes on, with feedback.

Running the Game

Whether it's a single session "one shot" game or a chronicle years in the execution, there are certain issues that may come up or advice that can prove useful for Storytellers seeking to keep their stories on the right track.

Be Descriptive!

This is perhaps the most basic bit of advice for players and Storytellers alike, but still a very useful reminder. While roleplaying games work with the power of the imagination, peoples' imaginations work even better when given fuel, and descriptions are that vital energy. The more descriptions the players are given, the more vivid a scene is; the more vivid a scene is, the easier the players can invest in it; the easier it is to invest in, the more a scene can inspire and engage the players to experience it to the fullest.

For their part, players also are encouraged to be descriptive when talking about their characters and the actions they take. "I dodge and then swing my sword at him" is fine, but "I laugh as I sidestep his clumsy attack, then bring my sword down for a cut across the back of his leg" is a lot more vivid and entertaining. Not every action needs to be so detailed, of course, and descriptions must line up with the rules where applicable — "I stab him through the heart and leave him gasping on the ground!" just doesn't line up with an attack that inflicts one level of damage on an otherwise healthy enemy — but it's still worth remembering to keep a game exciting.

While some Storytellers and players are naturally gifted with vivid descriptions, for others the habit can take some work. That's okay! One good way to get practiced at description it

is to try to include sensory details apart from just audio/visual information — bring up smells, tastes, and textures too. While sight and sound are important, invoking the other senses makes things more physical and immediate in ways those two base senses don't. Take the following example:

You walk into the convenience store. It's too cool and bright compared to the warm night outside, the music is bad pop through worse speakers, and the place smells like old dirt and fresh floor wax. A lone clerk and an equally-lonely hot dog seem to be the only ones inside.

It's not a long description, but it still manages to hit all five senses: sight (bright), sound (music), smell (dirt and floor wax), touch (cool), even taste (hot dog). Even if the players only spend a few minutes in the place, it will seem much more real and interesting than if the only description was "it's a normal convenience store at night."

Of course, being descriptive doesn't have to mean busting out the thesaurus and giving a half hour to each person the players happen to stumble across. It's not important what words are used, so much as giving the players an interesting description they can imagine. A thumbnail sketch can be just as evocative, with the added benefit of not taking as much time to share:

The clerk is middle-aged and pasty with thick glasses. He glances up as the door opens but doesn't really seem to see you before looking back down at his old paperback.

This description is pretty bare bones — no information on height, weight, hair color, clothes, etc. — but at the same time it captures some necessary details for the players to decide how they want to interact with him. On the whole, even just these spare details make the guy more real and memorable than just saying "there's a clerk inside and he looks really bored."

Of course, some more advanced techniques for description exist as well, for Storytellers who want to try out some interesting variations. For example, nothing says that a description can't editorialize a bit, or include a mood or ambiance that isn't strictly based on sensory details, so long as it serves to create an even more detailed impression of the scene. Continuing with the convenience store, the description might include:

That hum you hear could be quiet desperation... or maybe it's just the fluorescent lights.

This injects a little bit of humor into the scene, as well as a mood of tedium and dull routine that changelings tend to notice, if only as a harbinger of possible Banality. It's not really sensory information, but it definitely adds to the overall impression. These sorts of touches can also be used to reinforce theme and mood, provided they're not too common or heavy-handed.

Another popular advanced technique is sharing details with the players that the characters don't know yet. Although some groups avoid this approach, feeling that it spoils the surprise or makes it hard to separate player knowledge from character knowledge, it can still be quite effective at creating dramatic tension. Consider how it changes the convenience store scene if this little bit is added to the end of the description:

Meanwhile, in a darkened, parked car out back, one battered-looking redcap turns to another. "Put your mask on, idiot!" he snarls, tugging on a ski mask of his own. "And don't shoot nobody this time!"